Once I had sent in my acceptance, Mr. Gray of Wallerstein was ready to offer me a job, but it was too late. The die was cast.

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In making this decision, I completely ignored the potential earning power of my writing. Looking back on it now it might seem amazing that I did so, but at that time it would have been madness to do anything else.

Let me recapitulate.

Since the first moment I had stepped into Campbell's office on June 21, 1938, nearly eleven years had passed. In that interval of time I had written only science fiction, and I had reached the top of the tree. Campbell was the top of the tree.

I had written sixty stories in that eleven-year interval and had sold and been paid for forty-nine of them (fifty if you want to count the option of "Grow Old with Me"). Of these sales, twenty-eight had been to Campbell. In the past seven years, I had written eighteen stories and had sold seventeen of them to Campbell. (The exception was, of course, "Grow Old with Me.")

There was no place else for me to go. Heinlein had moved on to the slicks, but I knew I couldn't (or I thought I knew I couldn't).

Well, was it enough? Could I support myself writing?

No!

During my eleven years as a professional science-fiction writer who for seven years had been at the top of the tree, I had made a total of $7,593, or just about $700 a year. To be sure, I hadn't been a full-time writer at all, but my best year, 1944, had only brought in $1,100, and as

a full-time writer I would do well to double that, and $2,200 a year would not support me.

In fact, could I even double the rate at which I earned money if I spent full time at the typewriter? It wasn't writing time that was the bottleneck. You might remain at a typewriter hour after hour after hour, yet produce very little. What one needs is thinking time, and that can't be rushed. You have to think up your plots and your complications and your resolutions, so that most of your time is going to be spent thinking and not typing.